

course, be a limit to the amount of knowledge he can gain hands-on and in his city. If this person were to register on forums, his biking and computing experience is so much the richer. He not only has access to tips and tricks that members will contribute, but can learn from the experiences of others, get insights into what he can do better and how, perhaps learn something new, and make like-minded friends in the bargain. To top it off, forums are free, as the saying goes about some of the best things in life!

Another example: our very own www.thinkdigit.com/forum has members as diverse as you can get—techy geeks, total newbies, office-goers looking to enhance productivity, people looking for a single solution, and so on.

Arguments fly back and forth: why substitute the real thing for an online personality? Forums feature more informed human beings! If knowledge does equate to power, well, read on!

9.2 Classification Of People On A Forum

Most people join forums to share experiences, whether general or subjective. The simple fact is that a forum is an extension of one of our most important necessities—the necessity to communicate: our ideas, plans, expertise and dreams. The urge to socialise is inherent in all of us. Forums simply extend that sociable instinct online, where there is a virtually infinite audience, who participate equally—or not so!

Being an extension of a society—a sort of online society—a forum has to have an order of hierarchy. As in real life, some form of governance has to prevail, else chaos will ensue. Taking a hard-core PC enthusiast forum as an example, a distinction can be made based on the regularity of contributions, and of course the know-how of the contributor, as below.